2.1 The Second Great Awakening

Being part of a large gathering can be exciting and inspiring. In the mid-1800s, some religious events were so popular that they drew huge crowds, much like a music festival or sporting event does today.

MAIN IDEA In the early 19th century, new ideas about religion inspired people to reform problems in society.

A RETURN TO THE CHURCH

As you've read, the Enlightenment was a period in American history when political philosophers applied reason and logic to religion and society. New concepts about equality and government sparked the American Revolution. At the same time, scientific knowledge was expanding. The rush of new ideas caused many people to become skeptical of the power churches seemed to hold. Influenced by the Enlightenment, some people established new religions, such as Unitarianism, that combined the practical ideas of the Enlightenment with the teachings of the Bible.

In the 1790s, some Christians reexamined their religious practices. Many began to believe they should have a direct and emotional relationship with God. This movement is called the **Second Great Awakening**. To revive, or reawaken, religious enthusiasm, many Methodists and Baptists, among other denominations, organized **revival meetings**, or informal religious events held outdoors or in tents. Revivals became very popular because they drew people out of church buildings and into nature. Some preachers drew thousands of spectators. Audience members cried, shook, or rolled on the ground as preachers delivered sermons. Often, preachers **evangelized**, or spread the Christian gospel by delivering dramatic sermons and sharing personal experiences.

Many new believers joined Methodist and Baptist congregations as a result of the revivals. At these events, people felt a sense of freedom in worshiping with their friends and neighbors outside the formal organization of the church.

REFORMING SOCIAL PROBLEMS

One of the most prominent figures of the Second Great Awakening was a former lawyer and religious skeptic, or person who questions something others believe to be true, named **Charles Grandison Finney**. Finney became a fervent, or eager, Christian and preacher after his law studies led him to read and examine the Bible. He used his experience in arguing court cases to persuade others to adopt his beliefs.

Finney was as passionate about social reform as he was about his faith. He believed a just society had the responsibility to improve the lives of all its members. He delivered lively sermons calling for the end of slavery, the improvement of education for all citizens, and women's rights. Many other revivalist preachers shared Finney's views. As a result, religious groups actively promoted social reform causes.

The **temperance movement** was one part of this social reform effort. The word *temperance* means "moderation" or "self-restraint." This movement's proponents crusaded against the overuse of alcohol, which had become an integral part of daily life. On balance, 19th-century Americans consumed a lot of alcohol. In 1830, the average American drank seven gallons of alcohol per year—three times the average amount consumed today. Farmers earned extra money by making whiskey with leftover crops, local economies relied on alcohol sales, and drinking during working hours was commonplace. However, both public drunkenness and alcoholism had become significant social problems.

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CRITICAL VIEWING In 1839, J. Maze Burbank captured the fervor of a revival in his painting *Religious Camp Meeting.* Revival meetings were also known as "camp meetings." Most were located on the frontier where churches had yet to be built. How does this painting convey what people who attended this revival meeting might have experienced?

Temperance reformers approached the issue from different angles. Some wanted to curb the use of alcohol because they feared drunkenness was a threat to social order and economic prosperity. Others, motivated by the fervor of the Second Great Awakening, saw drinking as a sin. Some reformers wanted to protect women and children from neglect and mistreatment resulting from their husbands' and fathers' abuse of alcohol. Finally, medical professionals wanted Americans to limit their alcohol use for health reasons.

The reformers also looked beyond alcohol-related issues. They called attention to poor living conditions in overcrowded cities and advocated for working children's rights in factories and mills. Many, including California pioneer Annie Bidwell, also promoted free public education and voting rights for women.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What was the Second Great Awakening?
2. **DESCRIBE** How did Charles Grandison Finney play a significant role in society?
3. **COMPARE AND CONTRAST** What were the different ways in which reformers approached alcohol consumption in the 19th century?

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